

Buccal Mucosa (Cheek) Graft

Patient Information · The cheek graft used to rebuild your urethra or ureter

WARWIKI

During your repair surgery, your surgeon may take a small patch of the moist lining from inside your cheek. This is a buccal mucosa graft. It is used to rebuild your urethra or, less often, your ureter (the tube from a kidney to the bladder). This handout explains why the cheek is used and how your mouth will feel and heal.

About This Graft

The inside of your cheek is lined with tough, moist tissue. It is a good match for the urinary tract. A thin oval patch is taken from one cheek, or sometimes both for a longer repair. It is used to widen or rebuild the narrow area. The graft is taken **while you are asleep, during the same operation** as your repair.

Why the inside of the cheek?

- It has no hair and is used to being wet, like the urinary tract
- It is tough and heals well in its new place
- It is taken during the same surgery, and the scar is inside your mouth where no one sees it

Is It Safe?

Yes. Taking a cheek graft is a common, well-tested part of urethral surgery, and most people are satisfied. Your surgeon stays clear of the small tube that drains saliva and the corner of your mouth.

Most side effects are in the mouth: soreness, swelling, tightness or numbness. They usually ease over the first weeks. For some people, numbness or trouble opening the mouth wide lasts a long time, though it often bothers them little. Taking graft from both cheeks can cause more soreness, so it is used only when needed.

Learn the Terms

Buccal mucosa

The moist lining on the inside of your cheek.

Graft

A patch of your own tissue moved to repair another area.

Urethra

The tube that carries urine out of the body.

Urethroplasty

Surgery to repair or rebuild the urethra. The cheek graft is part of it.

Donor site

The place the graft is taken from. Here, it is the inside of your cheek.

General anesthesia

Medicine that keeps you asleep and pain-free during surgery.

Saliva (parotid) duct

A small opening inside the cheek that drains saliva. Your surgeon avoids it.

Trismus

Tightness or trouble opening the mouth wide. Gentle stretching helps.

Will it hurt? You are asleep, so you feel nothing during surgery. Afterward the cheek is sore, like a cheek bite or mouth ulcer, and may feel tight or numb. Pain medicine, cold drinks and soft food help. Soreness usually improves over the first 1–2 weeks.

First days	Weeks 1–2	Next few weeks	Months
Sore, swollen cheek. Cool liquids and soft food.	Soreness eases. Move toward a normal diet as you can.	The cheek keeps healing. Keep stretching your mouth open.	Numbness or tightness usually fades. For some, it lasts.

How to Get Ready

- Follow your surgery instructions about eating, drinking and which medicines to stop.
- Care for your mouth.** Brush and rinse well. Your team may ask you to have a dental cleaning first.
- Do not smoke, vape or use tobacco.** It slows healing of the mouth and the graft.

Tell your team ahead of time if you:

- Have had mouth, cheek or jaw surgery, or radiation to the head or neck
- Have a mouth condition, or trouble opening your mouth wide
- Chew tobacco or betel nut, or have dental problems

What Happens During Surgery

- You are asleep for the whole operation, and your mouth is gently held open.
- Your surgeon removes a thin oval patch of lining from one cheek, or both for a longer repair.
- The graft is shaped and used to widen or rebuild the narrow part of your urinary tract.
- The cheek is left to heal on its own or closed with stitches that dissolve. Trials have not shown that either way is clearly better.

After Surgery (Your Mouth)

- Eat **soft, bland foods** at first. Avoid spicy, sour, very hot or crunchy foods and alcohol. Rinse gently after eating.
- Gently **stretch your mouth open** each day to ease tightness.

Call the office that did your surgery if you have:

- A temperature of **100.4 °F (38 °C)** or higher, or chills
- Mouth pain or swelling that is getting worse, or pus
- You cannot drink enough fluids

Go to an emergency department if:

- Bleeding from the mouth that does not stop with firm pressure
- Mouth or neck swelling that makes it hard to swallow or breathe
- You cannot reach the office and are worried

Three Things to Remember

- A small patch from inside your cheek is used to rebuild your urethra. The scar is inside your mouth.
- The cheek is sore at first. It usually improves over 1–2 weeks.
- Eat soft food, rinse gently, and stretch your mouth open each day.